Once, he recounted a story about his return to Daultala, our ancestral village near Rawalpindi, when he was discharged from the army after the war in 1918. As he had been wounded and his right hand had been incapacitated, he could not maintain his beard and long unshorn hair. Consequently, he had to shave them off. On reaching home, he knocked on the door but my grandmother, Ram Rakhi, refused to let him in, asking, 'Who is this firanghee,' the native word for a European. She could not recognize him. Besides, he had acquired an even fairer complexion while recuperating in a hospital in the south of France. Theirs was a child marriage, as was customary then in the Punjab and in many other regions of India. It was only when he recounted to her some intimate details that she realized that he was, in fact, *her* Atma Singh, and she let him in. Then she asked him, 'What have you done to yourself?' He simply raised the right sleeve of his shirt and uncovered his dangling arm. That said it all! Some in the family had told her that those who crossed the seven oceans didn't ever come back. Of course, thousands didn't – they died in Kut-el-Amara or in Flanders. So she was delirious with joy and relief at my grandfather's homecoming and couldn't contain her tears.

When I was commissioned from the Indian Military Academy, Dehradun in 1964, my grandfather asked me, 'Kaka, kedi "paltan" mili hai tainu?' (Son, which regiment did you get?) When I told him it was the Maratha Light Infantry, he was very pleased, saying, 'Mahratte[2] bade bahadur te tagre honde han; taan hi unhan noon "lite infantry" da khitaab us jang vich milya si' (the Marathas are a very brave and hardy race; that is why during the war they were given the title of 'Light Infantry'). The bravery of the Marathas in battle was renowned from the days of Shivaji, and Maratha soldiers have been traditionally called ganpats. During the First World War, a letter from a German soldier describing the valour of the Indian soldiers and printed in the *Frankfurter Zeitung* said this:

> *Today for the first time we had to fight against the Indians and the devil knows that those brown rascals are not to be underrated. At first we spoke with contempt of the Indians. Today we learned to look on them in a different light – the devil knows what the English*